

Will Wii Rock You?

Nintendo, the ageing rock star, pops some pills, cuts its hair, and jumps on-stage singing a new tune and raring to go. Will the Wii herald a powerful comeback or be the swan's last song?

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Nintendo's history is a colourful one. The company started life in 1889 as a maker of Japanese playing cards. It then reinvented itself to become a toy company in the 1960s, and moved on to video games only in the 1970s. During this transition, the company cast itself as a love hotel and even as a taxi company!

Down the decades since its birth, Nintendo has seen both the zenith and the nadir of success. Many credit the company from single-

there was one. Nintendo thus enters the new console generation sore and defeated -squeezed on both the home console and handheld fronts by industry giants Sony and Microsoft, and their deep dollar pockets.

Thus cornered, 2004 surprisingly witnessed a resurgent Nintendo. One not afraid to throw the dice and take its chances; beaten perhaps, but daring to go; and singing a new tune. Today, Nintendo is betting on a revolution. With its mantra of "all-access gaming," it wants to change the way the world plays and views games. Under the leadership of once game designer and current president and CEO Satoru Iwata,



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handedly reviving the industry post the 1983 video game crash. While the company enjoyed great success with its NES home console system, it hasn't achieved that level of success since. Indeed, Sony usurped the home console crown with its release of the first PlayStation, and hasn't looked back since. Today, Nintendo enjoys a dominant position on the handheld console front, but has seen its home console share erode and its position slip to number three.

Its last console, the GameCube, has been declared to "not meet expectations", by the company itself—a euphemism for failure if ever

Nintendo would like to exorcise the "unsocial" tag associated with playing games—and simultaneously regain its long-lost crown.

Rising To Heaven

When Nintendo introduced the DS handheld in late 2004, nobody expected the ugly, fat handheld with two screens to stand a chance against Sony's sleeker, sexier, and much more powerful and capable PlayStation Portable. Nintendo's retired President Hiroshi Yamauchi was quoted by the Japanese *Nikkei Shimbun* newspaper as